

and urbanization. While the “Lost Cause” began largely as a Southern view, elements were absorbed into the national way of thinking over time. The most corrosive aspect, was that many U.S. citizens lost sight of the importance of slavery in the conflict’s beginnings and disavowed the significance of emancipation as one of the war’s great legacies. This historical amnesia and pro-Confederate revisionism lasted well into the 21st century. The United Daughters of the Confederacy (U.D.C.), founded in Nashville, Tennessee, in 1894, played a major role in promoting a revisionist agenda in school text books and in raising Confederate statues and memorials across the South.

Veterans’ organizations

While former soldiers found it difficult to discuss their time on the battlefield, they saw the value in creating veterans’ organizations. These groups enabled them to remain in contact with their comrades and provided a place in which to share their experiences. Former Union Army surgeon Benjamin Franklin Stephenson set up the Grand Army of the Republic (G.A.R.) in Decatur, Illinois, on April 6, 1866.

The organization was built on the tenets of “Fraternity, Charity, and Loyalty,” and soon expanded across the North and South, as regional posts were established. The G.A.R. held conventions nationally and played prominent roles in local civic rituals. Its members, who were restricted to the “veterans of the late unpleasantness,” numbered more than 400,000 in the 1890s, and the organization wielded significant political influence. It lobbied on behalf of its members on issues that included pensions and the care of veterans and their families.

The G.A.R. was instrumental in establishing May’s Decoration Day—which later became Memorial Day—as a national holiday, and it also formed an important constituency of the Republican Party. The organization was disbanded in 1956, following the death of its last member, Albert Woolson.